

mind, which was originally born at AT&T Labs. Dennis Ritchie and Brian Kernighan were the key people who created UNIX. Their book about C language programming became a truly classic edition in Russia, on the basis of which many generations of engineers are taught. The flexibility of Linux, the prevalence of the C language, and the philosophy of UNIX caused such widespread interest.

One of the first commercial companies that started working on the market was IPLabs Linux Team in 1998. It was initially involved in localisation activities, but later began to sell box versions as well—ranging from Mandrake to Red Hat and SuSE. Its tight cooperation with MandrakeSoft made it possible to create its own Linux distribution. In 2001, such distro-building experience led to the creation of a software-only company called AltLinux, with its own distribution carrying the same name as the company. After years of Linux experience, AltLinux now has the fourth largest repository in the world—Sisyphus. The AltLinux company builds server distributions for OEM companies and also builds desktop versions, as well as participating in government activities like the 'School Project'. In the fall of 2008, AltLinux produced the SKIF 4.1 distribution for the national supercomputer SKIF-MSU. In 2009, the company opened up a sales centre in Porto Alegre, Brazil.

In the year 2000, SWsoft had also decided to try its luck in the Linux world. It dedicated a special unit ASPLinux, which was supposed to bring a fully localised Russian distribution (with the same name—ASPLinux) based purely on Red Hat. It must be noted that the ASPLinux distro wasn't a simple clone of Red Hat, because it used several in-house-developed applications. For example, instead of LILO, it ran ASPLoader—a graphically enabled boot-strap utility. There were also ASPIInstaller and ASPDiskManager—a master disk partitioning utility. ASPLinux Server versions were pre-installed with virtualisation products named Virtuozzo—some open-source portions of which later evolved into OpenVZ technology. Due to certain reasons, the development of this distribution came to an end in 2008. Quite possibly SWsoft, already known as Parallels Inc, considered that it was commercially viable to develop the virtualisation business itself, rather than evolve in the Linux-friendly direction only. That's why we now see such brilliant technology as OpenVZ available almost in every hosting provider.

The story behind the MandrakeSoft company and its influence on the Russian Linux market was not simply limited by AltLinux in the late 90s. In 2007, Russian-based firm Mezon opened up a Mandriva Center of Competence located in St Petersburg. This enabled the firm to get the Mandriva distribution certified to be used in the government sector, as well as in places where confidential information was stored and processed. Moreover, three years later in 2010, the NGI Fund (with a Russian background) bought off majority stakes both in Mandriva as well as in the Russian company PingWin Software. This made it possible to perform systems integration and generate a new company—RosaLab. This step also allowed

Mandriva to be saved from collapsing. Now, by combining efforts to further develop Mandriva Linux, which now comes under the Rosa Linux name, RosaLab envisions converting Rosa Linux into a Russian nationwide distribution—but who knows what the future holds. However, saving the company in 2010 basically brought along many benefits. According to DistroWatch statistics (<http://distrowatch.com/stats.php?section=popularity>), Mandriva (or should I say Rosa Linux) again gained popularity.

In addition, a couple of other companies tried to develop their own distributions, though Linux wasn't their core business. This way, MOPSLinux appeared on the Russian market in 2004, originally developed by the Network company only for its own internal projects. The company was a developer of information systems for local administration units and enterprises. MOPSLinux is based on Slackware with Russian localisation and includes a number of applications developed in-house. The company offered technical support, both free and on a subscription basis. Unfortunately, in 2010 the company ceased Linux distribution, and apparently closed down—the financial crisis touched Russia too. Although several efforts were made to keep this distribution under the AgiliaLinux name, there are serious doubts it could continue being purely a voluntary project.

However, a better example is the experience of the Calculate company, for which the Linux business also isn't a major focus at all, because it produces cardboard and corrugated cardboard packaging. The company created a distribution called CalculateLinux for its own needs, when transferring its IT infrastructure to Linux in 2007. CalculateLinux is based on Gentoo Linux. Corporate graphical designers helped with the distribution's UI; that's why CalculateLinux has gained such popularity outside the mother company. Besides, free help is provided online via IRC and Jabber services.

All other distros could be considered more or less amateurish and non-professional from the business perspective—especially since all of them are designed for home users, and based on modern versions of either Ubuntu or Fedora from Red Hat.

When we start to discuss corporate Linux versions, both IT integrator companies and government agencies tend to use original and unmodified distributions such as RHEL, SLES, CentOS, Debian and AltLinux Server. It should also be noted that the Ministry of Defence has its own versions of Linux called MCBC—a Mobile System for the Armed Forces. The government research institute created it early in 2003 on a Red Hat Linux base, with broad consultancy support from one of Russia's Red Hat partners. Fundamentally, there's nothing special about MCBC though—a simplified UI interface *a la* Windows95 and certified internal components to monitor access to the system. What could be particularly interesting is the fact that MCBC has been ported to MIPS, x86 and SPARC platforms. The system is distributed among large government customers on a paid basis and isn't available in the public domain.